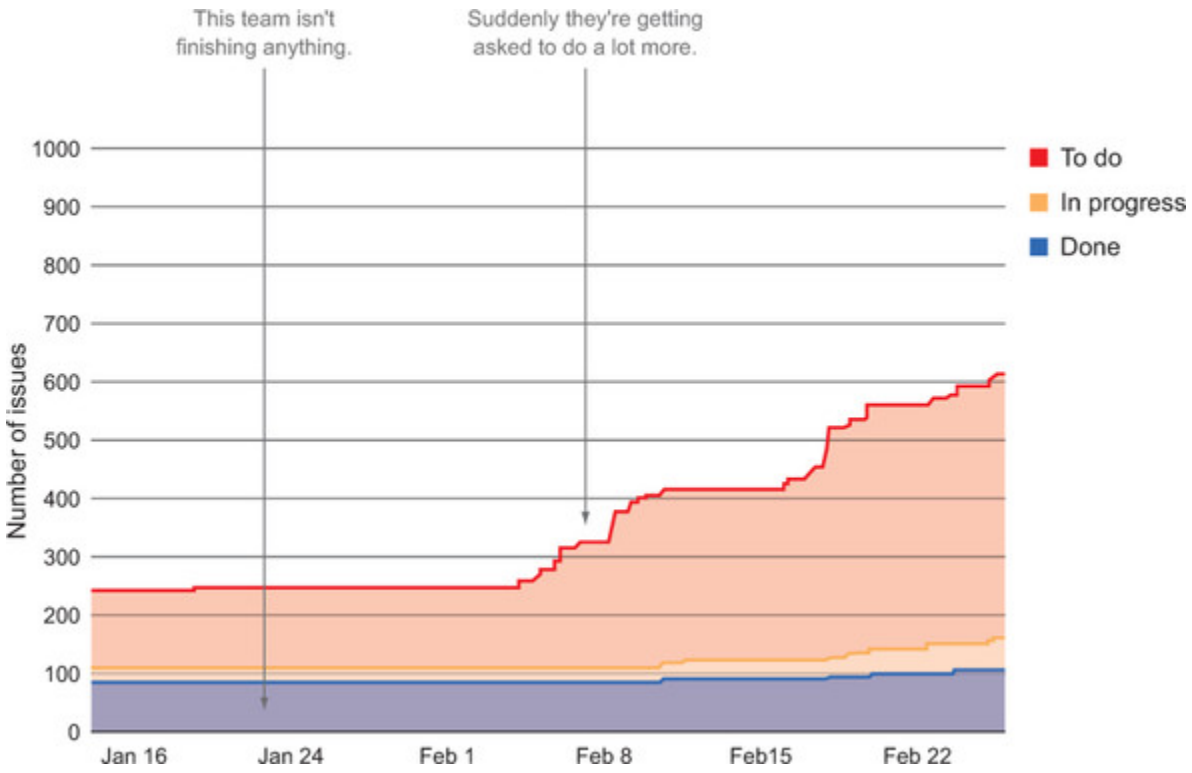
3.1.3. Cumulative flow

Cumulative flow shows how much work aggregated by type is allocated to your team over time. The cumulative flow diagram is typically used for identifying bottlenecks in the process by visually representing when a type of task is increasing faster than the others. In figure 3.4 you see an example cumulative flow diagram where a team is completing hardly any work and suddenly their to-do list jumps off the charts.

Figure 3.4. An example cumulative flow diagram showing a team getting asked to do a lot more than they have been able to accomplish historically



As with other charts, this tells only a part of the picture. It’s possible that tasks were simply too big and the team started breaking them down into smaller chunks. It’s also possible that this team is struggling to complete work and they end up getting more work piled on as an unrealistic task.

Cumulative flow can be useful when you use the correct task types for your work. If you have tasks for integration and you see that part of your graph